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Play Equity Fund Secures $4 Million in State Funding for the Youth Sports For All Act, Positioning California as a National Leader in Play Equity

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LOS ANGELES, July 13, 2026 (GLOBE NEWSWIRE) -- Cheers and excitement filled the room as dozens of children and supporters gathered to celebrate California's historic $4 million investment in the Youth Sports For All Act. The landmark legislation propels the state to the forefront of the play equity movement, and expands opportunities for every child to participate in youth sports, physical activity, and structured play.

Assemblymember Tina McKinnor (D-Inglewood) announced that the Youth Sports For All Act will receive this historic investment in California's youth. The Youth Sports For All Act creates a Blue-Ribbon Commission, led by the California Health and Human Services Agency, to examine the landscape of youth sports and make recommendations for establishing a centralized entity to ensure equitable access to quality sports programs for all youth in California by 2028.

The Play Equity Fund led the successful campaign for the Youth Sports For All Act, uniting communities, advocates, and partners across California in a statewide movement that helped secure this historic investment. The funding marks a significant step forward in ensuring that every child in California has access to sports, physical activity, and structured play.

The celebration brought together supporters from across Southern California, including Olympians and Paralympians, professional sports teams, community leaders, members of the Los Angeles Play Equity Coalition, and youth advocates. They gathered at the Terasaki Budokan, a community sports center in the historic Little Tokyo district of Los Angeles, to commemorate this milestone achievement.

Introduced by Assemblymember McKinnor, the landmark Youth Sports For All Act was sponsored by the Play Equity Fund, and the organization's research shows that while youth sports provide numerous lifelong benefits, including improved physical and mental health, academic success, and other social skills, participation rates vary significantly across racial and socioeconomic lines in the nation's most populous state.

"It was a full-court press to make sure the Blue-Ribbon Commission will have the resources they need to do this important work," McKinnor said. "Because every California child should have the ability to engage in sports."

A broad coalition of over 50 organizations supported the legislation, from a legion of grassroots youth sports providers working with children in communities statewide, to Play Equity Fund partners such as Angel City Football Club, the Los Angeles Dodgers, the Los Angeles Rams, the Los Angeles Sparks, and Nike.

Governor Gavin Newsom, Assembly Budget Chair Jesse Gabriel, Senator Ben Allen, and Senator Lola Smallwood-Cuevas were also recognized during the event for their leadership and efforts to secure funding for this meaningful investment in youth sports and play.

"The lack of access to sports, play, and movement for children is a challenge that one organization cannot solve alone," Simril said. "It requires a systems-level solution to create play equity, and California leaders recognized that with the Youth Sports For All Act."

The Blue-Ribbon Commission is slated to deliver its recommendations to the California State Legislature in 2028, when Los Angeles hosts the LA28 Olympic and Paralympic Games.

The Blue-Ribbon Commission aims to create a lasting statewide system that ensures every child in California has

equitable access to quality sports and play opportunities as an indelible legacy of the 2028 Games.

DeMari Wilson, a 15-year-old student participating in summer sports programming at the Terasaki Budokan, described what the new law means to him and his peers for everyone assembled.

"Every kid deserves the chance to play no matter their situation," Wilson said. "As we step into a new era of play, I hope to see many kids having fun."

About the Play Equity Fund

The Play Equity Fund is the charitable partner of the LA84 Foundation, legacy of the 1984 Summer Olympic Games in Los Angeles. The Play Equity Fund supports the sports-based youth development ecosystem, raises awareness of inequities, and develops partnerships to advocate for sustainable solutions to ensure children from all backgrounds have pathways to lifelong well-being and success through sport. By creating social impact programs with its partners that focus on community and young people, the Play Equity Fund shows access to sport is not a privilege but a fundamental right for all. Visit playequityfund.org and follow @playequityfund.

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A photo accompanying this announcement is available at https://www.globenewswire.com/NewsRoom/AttachmentNg/fde111ce-df39-4325-83eb-18d9e0f75a60

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